FREE GUIDE

The Preschool Decision Guide

Compiled by Starling Montessori for parents navigating Capitol Hill, Brookland, and Eastern Market preschools.

CAPITOL HILL · WASHINGTON, D.C.

A note before you begin

When we were getting Starling off the ground, one of the things we kept wishing for was a simple, honest resource — something a friend who had already done this search might hand you. Not a brochure from a school, not a ranking list, but a real walkthrough of the questions to ask, the things to notice, and the parts of this process that tend to catch families off guard.

This guide is our attempt to write that resource. We drew on conversations with Capitol Hill families, our own experience opening a school, and years spent inside Montessori classrooms. It covers timelines, how to read different philosophies, what to ask on tours, and what to listen for when something feels slightly off.

We wrote it to be useful across any school — not just ours. You will find one short section about Starling toward the end, but everything before that is meant to serve your search regardless of where it leads.

Our hope is that after reading this, the whole process feels a little less like navigating a mystery and a little more like making a thoughtful choice for your family.

This guide was made to help you find the right preschool for your family — even if that's not Starling.

— Fabienne Deaton, Founder

When to start looking

The DC preschool application calendar moves earlier than most families expect. Here is a rough timeline to orient yourself — though specifics vary significantly from school to school.

- **12–18 months before your target start date:** Begin your initial research. Read about philosophies, make a list of schools in your neighborhoods, and start attending any open house events you can find. This is the time for observation and questions, not decisions.
- **6–12 months before your target start date:** Narrow your list to four or five schools. Schedule tours. Many DC schools open their tour calendars in the fall for the following school year, so September through November is often a busy window.
- **4–8 months before your target start date:** Complete applications. Most private preschool applications in DC open in October–November and close in December–January. Public lottery schools (DC Pre-K, DCPS) operate on a separate calendar — typically opening in late January.
- **3–5 months before your target start date:** Receive acceptances and make your decision. Deposit deadlines vary. If you receive an offer you want, read the enrollment agreement carefully before signing — look for sibling priority policies, withdrawal refund terms, and tuition adjustment language.
- **1–3 months before your target start date:** Complete enrollment paperwork, health forms, and orientation. Begin your family's gradual transition preparation.

Every school in DC keeps its own calendar. Always confirm dates directly with each school.

Understanding the main approaches

Most preschools you will consider in DC fall into one of these categories. None is universally better — each fits different children differently.

Approach	*Best suited for…*	*Daily structure*	*Typical DC tuition range (full-day, 2026)*
Montessori (AMI)	Children who thrive with independence and self-directed work; families who value a specific, research-rooted method with consistent international standards	Uninterrupted 3-hour work cycle; child chooses work from prepared materials; mixed-age classroom; guide facilitates rather than directs	$2,200 – $2,800 / month
Montessori (AMS)	Families seeking Montessori principles with slightly more flexibility; broader range of teacher training backgrounds	Similar uninterrupted work cycle; some schools blend Montessori materials with other curricula; mixed-age or single-age depending on school	$1,900 – $2,500 / month
Reggio Emilia	Children who flourish through project-based exploration; families who value documentation of learning and strong home–school communication	Project-based, emergent curriculum; children's questions drive units of study; collaborative small-group work; atelier (studio space) central to most programs	$2,000 – $2,600 / month
Play-Based	Children who need open-ended time and social exploration; families who prioritize social-emotional development and flexibility	Large blocks of free-choice play; structured group times (circle, story, music); less formal academic preparation than Montessori or Reggio	$1,800 – $2,400 / month
Forest / Outdoor	Children who need movement, sensory engagement, and time in nature; families comfortable with weather-dependent programming	Majority of day spent outdoors year-round; loose-parts play; nature-based materials; physical risk-taking encouraged within structured safety protocols	$1,800 – $2,200 / month

A few notes on how to use this table: tuition ranges reflect full-day enrollment at established private schools in the DC area as of spring 2026 and will vary by specific school, hours, and what is included in tuition. Part-day programs are typically less. Many schools also exist on a spectrum between these categories — a school may call itself Montessori-inspired without holding AMI or AMS credentials, which is worth asking about directly.

12 questions to ask at every tour

Bring this list with you. Not every school will welcome all of these questions, and that itself is useful information.

1. **What is the teacher-to-child ratio in my child's classroom?**
   Notes:

2. **How long have the lead teachers been with the school?**
   Notes:

3. **How do you handle separation anxiety in the first weeks?**
   Notes:

4. **What is the daily schedule, hour by hour?**
   Notes:

5. **How are families notified about incidents or accidents?**
   Notes:

6. **What is your discipline philosophy and how is it applied in the classroom?**
   Notes:

7. **How do you communicate with parents day to day?**
   Notes:

8. **What happens when a child is having a difficult day?**
   Notes:

9. **How do you support children transitioning to the next age group?**
   Notes:

10. **What is the path to elementary school from here?**
    Notes:

11. **What does a typical day look like for the youngest child in the classroom?**

    Notes:

12. **May I observe a classroom in session — not just see the empty space?**

    Notes:

8 signs worth watching for

These are observations, not verdicts. A single sign on its own is worth noting; several together are worth taking seriously.

1. **The tour does not include observation of a real classroom in session.**
   An empty classroom tells you about furniture and materials. A classroom in session tells you about the culture. Most thoughtful schools are glad to let prospective families observe — with appropriate notice and respect for the children's work time. If observation is never offered, or if the invitation comes with significant resistance, it is worth understanding why.

2. **The director cannot describe the school's philosophy clearly in their own words.**
   You do not need a rehearsed elevator pitch. What you are listening for is whether the director can speak fluently and personally about how children learn at their school — not recite the website. Hesitation around this question, or reliance on printed materials alone, may suggest the philosophy has not fully permeated the leadership.

3. **Teacher turnover is high, or the school will not share turnover information.**
   Consistency of caregivers matters enormously to young children. A school that has cycled through several lead teachers in recent years is worth asking about — transitions happen for legitimate reasons, but a pattern of instability has real consequences for the children in the classroom. If the school declines to discuss turnover at all, that is also useful information.

4. **Communication tools feel chaotic or inconsistent.**
   You will rely on this school's communication system through illnesses, behavioral moments, schedule changes, and the small daily things that matter when your child is not with you. A school that cannot clearly describe how it communicates — or that uses five different platforms with no consistent cadence — may make that part of your life harder than it needs to be.

5. **The school presses you to commit on the spot.**
   Enrollment decisions involve real money and a meaningful commitment of your family's time and trust. A school that creates artificial urgency — implying the seat will be gone before you reach your car — is prioritizing its own enrollment timeline over your ability to make a thoughtful decision. Legitimate scarcity is real, but it can be communicated calmly.

6. **They cannot tell you the names of the current lead teachers.**
   Your child will spend most of their days with one or two specific people. If the school cannot readily tell you who those people are — their names, their training, how long they have been there — that absence of information is worth noticing.

7. **Outdoor time is less than 30 minutes per day.**

Current research on child development is consistent on this point: regular outdoor time supports attention, self-regulation, gross motor development, and general wellbeing. Some programs in dense urban buildings have real constraints, but it is still worth asking how outdoor time is handled and what children do when weather limits options.

8. **They will not let you speak with current parents.**
   A school that is confident in its community is generally glad to connect you with families who are enrolled. An outright refusal — beyond a reasonable privacy note about not sharing contact information directly — may suggest the school is uncertain about what current families would say.

A note on tuition and what it includes

Full-day preschool tuition in Washington DC runs roughly $1,800 to $2,800 per month for private programs in 2026, depending on the philosophy, location, hours, and whether the school holds specific credentials. This is a wide range, and the sticker number alone does not tell you much about value or fit.

What tuition typically includes varies considerably from school to school. Some programs bundle lunch, snacks, and all supplies into the monthly rate. Others charge separately for meals, materials, field experiences, or an annual registration fee that can run $500 to $1,500. Before comparing two schools on tuition, it is worth asking each school for a full breakdown of what is and is not covered — the all-in monthly cost is often different from the headline figure.

A few things to look for specifically when reviewing an enrollment agreement:

- Whether a registration or enrollment deposit is refundable, and under what conditions
- Whether tuition rates are locked for the full year or subject to mid-year adjustment
- What the withdrawal policy is, and how many weeks of notice are required
- Whether sibling priority is written into the agreement or simply a stated preference

Regarding how Starling Montessori handles pricing specifically: Tuition rates vary based on our program schedules. Please reach out to us directly and indicate the programs you are interested in to receive more information regarding rates & pricing.

We share this not to be coy, but because the right program schedule for your family is a conversation worth having — and the number makes most sense once we understand what you are looking for.

Questions to ask yourself

After each tour, before you compare notes with your co-parent or partner, try sitting quietly with these for a few minutes. The answers are not scored — they are just a way to let your own observations surface.

- What is your gut feeling about the director after the tour? Not their credentials — their presence and how they spoke about the children.
- Can you imagine your child genuinely happy here for two or three years? Not on a good day — on a hard day, when they need something specific.
- Does the school's stated value system feel consistent with how the adults in the building actually behaved during your visit?
- Is the location workable for your daily routine — not just in September, but in February, in the rain, when you are running late?
- What about this place do you think your child might carry with them, even without being able to name it?
- If you had to explain to a close friend why you chose this school, what would you say first?

A short glossary

These terms come up often in preschool conversations and are not always used consistently. Here are plain definitions.

Montessori vs. Montessori-inspired
A school using the name "Montessori" may or may not hold any formal credential — the name is not trademarked. "Montessori-inspired" often signals that a school incorporates some Montessori materials or ideas without full adherence to the method. Asking whether a school's guides hold AMI or AMS credentials is the clearest way to assess the depth of training.

Toddler Community vs. Primary Classroom
In the Montessori framework, a Toddler Community serves children roughly 16 months to 3 years old, with a curriculum centered on practical life, movement, and early language. The Primary Classroom serves children ages 3 to 6, with a broader curriculum including sensorial, language, mathematics, and cultural materials. These are distinct environments with different training requirements for guides.

Mixed-age classroom
A classroom that intentionally groups children across two or three ages rather than separating them by birth year. In Montessori practice, this reflects a belief that younger children learn by observing older ones, and older children consolidate understanding by helping younger ones. The three-year age span in a Primary classroom is considered integral to the method, not simply a scheduling convenience.

Three-year cycle
The principle that a child benefits from spending three years in the same Montessori classroom environment — progressing from the youngest child who is new to the space, to the middle child who is consolidating skills, to the eldest child who leads and mentors. Interrupting this cycle by moving a child early is generally discouraged in authentic Montessori practice.

Half-day vs. full-day
Half-day programs typically run three to four hours, often 8:30 or 9:00 to noon or 12:30. Full-day programs extend to 3:00 or later, and may include lunch and a rest period. Some schools offer both options, sometimes with different tuition and different classroom compositions. Extended care beyond the core hours is a separate question from the program day itself.

AMI Diploma
A credential awarded by the Association Montessori Internationale, the organization founded by Maria Montessori herself. AMI diplomas are issued for specific age levels (0–3, 3–6, 6–12) and require an intensive period of theoretical study, observation hours, and examined practical work. The 3–6 AMI diploma is considered by many practitioners to represent the most rigorous preparation for guiding a Primary classroom.

AMS Credential
A credential awarded by the American Montessori Society. AMS-credentialed teachers have completed a recognized Montessori teacher education program affiliated with AMS. Training standards vary across affiliated programs, but the credential indicates a substantive engagement with Montessori principles. Some schools hold both AMI and AMS affiliations.

Prepared environment
A central concept in Montessori philosophy referring to a classroom designed intentionally for the child — materials at child height, beauty and order as deliberate choices, and an organization that allows children to select and return work independently. The guide's job includes maintaining this environment as an active teaching tool, not simply as furniture arrangement.

Practical Life work
A category of Montessori materials and activities that engage children in real tasks modeled on daily life: pouring, spooning, folding, washing, lacing, cutting. Practical Life work is not filler — it develops fine motor control, concentration, sequencing, and a sense of purposeful accomplishment that underpins later academic work.

Drop-off ratio
The ratio of adults to children at the moment of morning drop-off, which is distinct from the in-classroom ratio during the school day. Drop-off is often the most emotionally complex part of a young child's day, and how a school manages that transition — who is present, how greeting is handled, how long the process takes — can significantly affect how the rest of the morning goes.

About Starling Montessori

If you would like to learn more about us specifically, here is how we approach AMI Montessori on Capitol Hill.

- **Family-run, founded by Fabienne Deaton.** Fabienne holds two AMI Diplomas — for the 0–3 and 3–6 age levels — and has spent years inside Montessori classrooms before opening Starling. The school is not a franchise or a chain. Decisions about how the school operates are made by people who are inside it every day.
- **Intentionally small.** Starling operates one Toddler Community and is opening a Primary Classroom in August 2026 with twelve inaugural seats. The small size is not a limitation we are working to overcome — it is a deliberate choice that affects how well every guide knows every child.
- **AMI-trained guides and authentic Montessori practice.** Our guides hold AMI credentials for their respective levels. We follow the AMI curriculum and the prepared environment philosophy as described in the glossary above — not as a marketing description, but as a daily practice.

We welcome tours by appointment, but feel free to reach out with any questions about your search even if Starling is not right for you. We are happy to recommend other Capitol Hill schools that might fit better.

Using this guide on your tours

The most practical way to use this guide is to print the "12 questions" section and bring it with you on each tour. You do not need to work through every question in order — treat it as a reference you can glance at when a natural opening comes up in conversation. The notes line below each question is there for exactly that: a few words you can jot down while the impression is fresh, before you get back in the car.

The "8 signs worth watching for" section works best as a private checklist you revisit after each visit rather than a live score card during the tour. After you have seen three or four schools, the patterns tend to become clearer. And the "Questions to ask yourself" section is worth returning to more than once — often the answers shift between your first read and your third tour, and that shift is itself informative.

When you are ready

If you have questions at any point during your search — about Capitol Hill schools in general, about Montessori, or about whether Starling might be a fit — you are welcome to reach out directly to Fabienne at info@starlingmontessorischool.com.

That invitation extends to questions about other schools as well. If there is a program you have heard about and want a candid perspective on, or if you are trying to think through a decision between two options that do not include Starling, reach out anyway. The goal of this guide — and of that conversation — is for your family to find the right place, whatever that turns out to be.

We wish you a thoughtful search.